

MOTIVATIONAL INTERVIEWING OVERVIEW

Eliciting change talk

The fifth skill 'eliciting change talk' is a strategy for helping the patient to resolve ambivalence and is aimed at enabling the patient to present the arguments for change. There are four main categories of change talk:

- Recognizing the disadvantages of staying the same
- Recognizing the advantages of change
- Expressing optimism about change
- Expressing an intention to change.

There are a number of ways of drawing out change talk from the patient.

- Asking direct open questions; for example:
 - "What worries you about your substance use?"*
 - "What do you think will happen if you don't make any changes?"*
 - "What would be the good things about cutting down your substance use?"*
 - "How would you like your life to be in five years time?"*
 - "What do you think would work for you if you decided to change?"*
 - "How confident are you that you can make this change?"*
 - "How important is it to you to cut down your substance use?"*
 - "What are you thinking about your substance use now?"*
- Use the importance and confidence rulers (see figure 3 and figure 4, Miller and Rollnick¹³) suggest using the ruler to obtain the patient's rating and then asking the following two questions.
 - "Why are you at a (eg. 3) and not a 0?"* This gets the patient to verbally justify, or defend, their position which can act to motivate the patient to change.
 - "What would it take for you to go from a (eg. 3) to a (eg. 6) (a higher number)?"*
This gets patients to verbalize possible strategies for change and gets them to start thinking more about change.
- Probe the decision balance (see figure 2) by encouraging the patient to talk about the benefits of change and the costs of staying the same.
- Ask the patient to clarify or elaborate their statements - for example, a person who reports that one of the less good things about using cocaine is having panic attacks could be asked:
 - "Describe the last time this happened."*
 - "What else?"*
 - "Give me an example of that."*
 - "Tell me more about that?"*
- Ask the patient to imagine the worst consequences of not changing or the best consequences of changing.
- Explore the patient's goals and values to identify discrepancies between the patient's values and their current substance use. For example, ask:
 - "What are the most important things in your life?"*

¹² Miller W. (1983) Motivational interviewing with problem drinkers. Behavioural Psychotherapy. 11:147-172

¹³ Miller, R. and Rollnick, S. (2013) Motivational Interviewing: Helping People Change. 3rd Edition. Guilford Press.
<http://www.ytporegon.org/content/spirit-motivational-interviewing>.